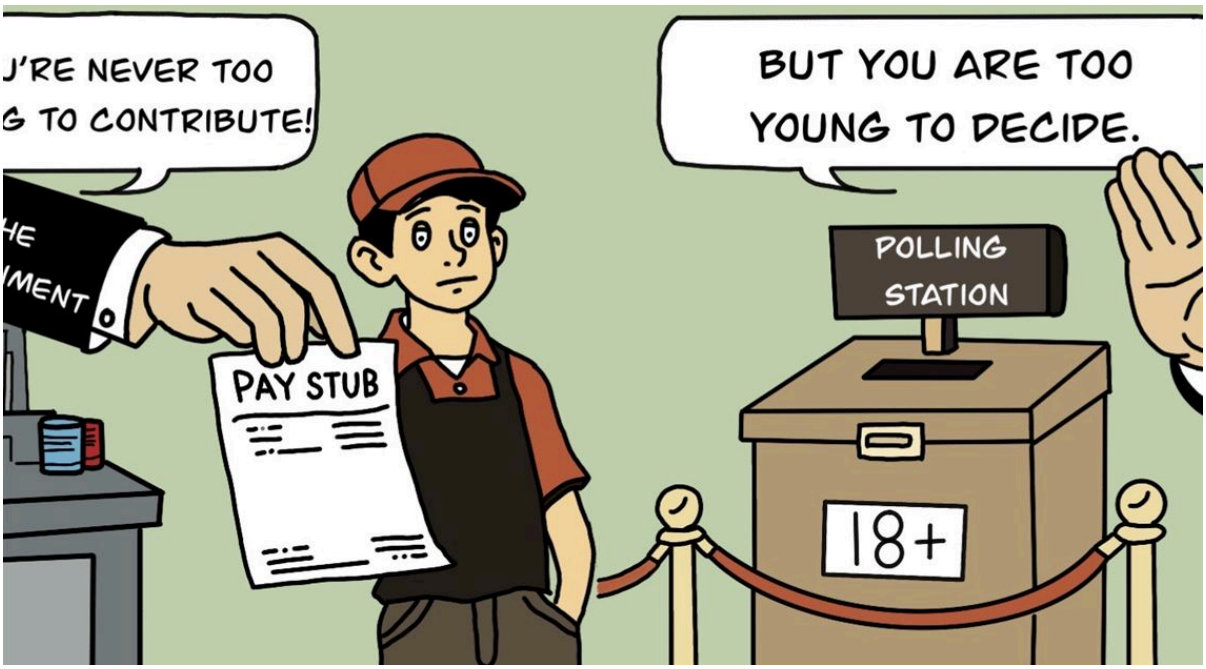

Vikrant Kamat: The government wants my money but not my thoughts

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Insight

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At 16, I can legally work. I can earn money that helps pay for school expenses, transportation and family costs. The government has no hesitation about taxing that income. Yet when Election Day comes around, I am told I am too young to have a voice in deciding how those tax dollars are used.

The government says "You're never too young to contribute," and at the same time says, "You're too young to decide." But deciding is one way to contribute. People my age can contribute in one way but not the other. That contradiction deserves more attention than it gets.

A distant principle

"No taxation without representation!" These were the words cried through the streets of Boston — and through our classrooms all through our years of schooling — when our country's founders protested a government that

taxed them without giving them a voice. The idea was simple: If the government takes your money, it owes you representation in return.

More than two centuries later, that principle feels distant to people my age who work part-time jobs, see taxes withheld from their paychecks and realize they are contributing to a system that does not allow them any say in how it operates.

Our forefathers rallied for this very issue. They built a political system around the belief that government power must be tied to consent, especially when it comes to taxation. That idea was not abstract.

It was rooted in the belief that people who contribute to a government have the right to influence it. That belief shaped the country's earliest arguments for democracy, yet it is one we quietly set aside when it comes to working teenagers today.

If civic responsibility includes contributing financially to the public good, then civic rights should follow closely behind.

I live in a community where it is not uncommon to see teenagers work. Some save for college, help their families with groceries or maybe just want a little extra money. When lawmakers debate minimum wage laws, school funding or public transportation, those decisions directly affect teenage workers. Yet we are expected to accept the outcomes quietly until we turn 18.

Poor objections

The most common objection to lowering the voting age is maturity. Critics argue that 16-year-olds lack the judgment or knowledge to vote responsibly. And while that concern is valid, it rests on an idealized view of how voting works in practice.

The right to vote has never been conditioned on political sophistication or knowledge on the matter. Adults are not required to pass a civics test or demonstrate independence of thought before entering the voting booth.

Many vote based on habit, emotion or family influence. That reality is accepted as part of democracy.

The idea of tax refunds is sometimes raised as a justification for the status quo as if money returned months later resolves the imbalance. But refunds do not change the basic structure of how the system works. Teenagers who work are included financially before they are included civically.

Whether an amount that fluctuates annually and is often later returned does not alter when contribution begins or when participation is allowed. For working teenagers, involvement comes early, while representation remains deferred, separated not by principle but by age.

Teenagers are already entrusted with serious responsibilities, with some working, managing school and job schedules, and in some cases, taking care of their younger siblings. Civic participation is treated as uniquely dangerous as if operating 6,000 pounds of heavy machinery is less perilous than casting a ballot.

Easily overlooked

One reason this issue rarely gains attention is that teenagers are easy to overlook. They are not a reliable voting bloc, they do not donate to campaigns and they rarely appear in polling data. As a result, the contradiction of taxing young workers while excluding them from elections is rarely examined. Allowing 16-year-olds to vote would bring that contradiction into the open, making it harder to ignore.

I am not arguing that every teenager is ready to vote wisely. Neither is every adult. Democracy has always accepted that risk in exchange for fairness and legitimacy. What weakens trust is a system that takes teenagers' money while dismissing their voices.

If we believe that contributing to society matters, then representation should not be delayed simply because it is inconvenient. At the very least, we should acknowledge that working teenagers already meet one of democracy's core expectations.

If I am old enough to be taxed, I should be old enough to be heard.

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